NORTHSTAR TECHNOLOGIES

Sample Employee Handbook and HR Policy Guide
Synthetic document for Spring AI Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) testing

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Document owner: People Operations | **Applies to:** U.S.-based employees

IMPORTANT: Northstar Technologies is a fictional company. All employee benefits, contacts, figures, deadlines, and policies below are invented for software demonstrations. This is not legal, HR, or employment advice.

1. Employment classifications and work schedule

Full-time employees are scheduled for 40 hours per week and generally qualify for company benefits. Part-time employees are scheduled for fewer than 30 hours per week and may qualify for benefits only where a plan or applicable law requires. Temporary employees are hired for specified assignments. Employees are designated exempt or non-exempt as required by applicable law.

Core collaboration hours are Monday through Friday, 10:00 AM to 3:00 PM Central Time. Outside core hours, teams may arrange flexible schedules with manager approval. Employees must accurately record work time where required. Overtime for non-exempt employees requires advance manager approval, but all time worked must be reported and will be paid in accordance with law.

2. Paid time off (PTO)

Full-time employees receive 15 days (120 hours) of PTO per calendar year, accrued at 10 hours per month. New hires begin accruing PTO on their first day. PTO requests of three or more consecutive workdays should be submitted at least 10 calendar days in advance. Managers normally respond within three business days.

Employees may carry over up to 5 unused PTO days (40 hours) into the next calendar year. Carried-over PTO must be used by March 31 or is forfeited unless prohibited by law. PTO payout at separation follows applicable state law. Sick or protected leave rights under law take precedence over conflicting handbook rules.

3. Holidays and sick leave

The company observes eight paid holidays: New Year's Day, Martin Luther King Jr. Day, Memorial Day, Independence Day, Labor Day, Thanksgiving Day, the day after Thanksgiving, and Christmas Day. If a holiday falls on a weekend, People Operations announces the observed weekday.

Full-time employees receive 5 paid sick days (40 hours) per calendar year. Sick leave can be used for the employee's illness, medical appointment, or care for a qualifying family member. Employees should notify their manager as soon as practical. Additional or different leave is provided when legally required.

4. Remote work and office attendance

Eligible employees may work remotely up to 3 days per week. Unless a written team exception applies, they work onsite at least 2 days per week. The standard onsite days are Tuesday and Thursday. A manager may approve a temporary exception lasting up to 30 calendar days; longer arrangements require People Operations approval.

Employees working remotely must use company-managed devices, a secure connection, and approved collaboration tools. Working outside the employee's approved state or country requires prior written approval from People Operations and Information Security.

5. Compensation and payroll

Employees are paid twice per month, on the 15th and final calendar day. If a scheduled payday falls on a weekend or bank holiday, payroll is processed on the preceding business day. Pay statements are available in the employee payroll portal. Payroll errors should be reported to payroll@northstar.example within five business days after discovery.

Annual performance reviews occur in February. Compensation changes are discretionary and are not guaranteed by performance reviews. Expense reimbursements are processed separately from wages.

6. Health insurance and retirement benefits

Eligible full-time employees may enroll in medical, dental, and vision plans. Medical coverage generally begins on the first day of the month after 30 days of employment, subject to plan terms. New hires must submit their benefit elections within 30 calendar days of their start date. Qualifying life events may permit changes outside open enrollment.

The company offers a 401(k) plan with a 100% employer match on the first 4% of eligible compensation contributed by the employee. Employees may enroll after 90 days of employment, subject to plan documentation. The employer match is immediately vested in this fictional sample plan. Statutory contribution limits apply.

7. Parental and family leave

Eligible full-time employees who have completed 12 months of service may receive 6 weeks of company-paid parental leave following birth, adoption, or placement of a child. Leave must be coordinated with People Operations and may run concurrently with applicable statutory leave. Employees should give at least 30 days' notice when foreseeable. Other legally protected leave remains available as required by law.

8. Employee equipment and IT support

Each new full-time employee receives a company laptop and standard accessories. New equipment requests are submitted through the internal IT Service Desk. Lost or stolen devices must be reported to security@northstar.example immediately and no later than 24 hours after discovery. Employees may not install unapproved software or share corporate passwords.

IT support operates Monday through Friday from 8:00 AM to 6:00 PM Central Time. High-priority security incidents can be reported 24/7 to security@northstar.example. Company devices and accounts must be returned or disabled at separation according to offboarding instructions.

9. Business travel and expenses

Business travel requires manager approval before booking. Employees must submit expense reports within 30 calendar days of the expense date, including itemized receipts for purchases of $25 or more. Approved reimbursements are generally issued within 10 business days after a complete report is approved.

Sample meal reimbursement caps are $20 for breakfast, $30 for lunch, and $45 for dinner, excluding taxes and tips, unless otherwise pre-approved. Alcohol is not reimbursable under this sample policy. Business-class airfare requires vice-president approval.

10. Learning and professional development

Full-time employees who have completed 90 days of service are eligible for a professional development budget of up to $1,200 per calendar year. Eligible costs include job-related courses, certification exams, and technical conferences. Manager approval is required before purchase. Unused amounts do not roll over to the next year.

11. Performance, conduct, and reporting concerns

Managers conduct quarterly check-ins and an annual review in February. Employees must follow the code of conduct, information-security guidelines, and anti-harassment policies. Complaints may be raised with a manager or People Operations at hr@northstar.example. The company prohibits retaliation for good-faith reports. Reports will be reviewed as promptly and confidentially as practicable.

12. Resignation and offboarding

Employees are asked to provide at least two weeks' written notice of voluntary resignation when possible. Final pay and accrued leave treatment follow applicable law. Before departure, employees must return laptops, badges, access tokens, and other company property. People Operations provides separation and benefits information as appropriate.

13. HR contacts and escalation

General HR: hr@northstar.example
Payroll: payroll@northstar.example
Benefits: benefits@northstar.example
IT service desk: it@northstar.example
Security incidents: security@northstar.example

For an ordinary policy question, employees should contact hr@northstar.example. For a payroll discrepancy, email payroll@northstar.example. For a lost laptop or suspected security incident, email security@northstar.example immediately.

14. Frequently asked questions (RAG evaluation)

Q: How many PTO days do full-time employees receive?

A: 15 days (120 hours) per calendar year, accrued at 10 hours each month.

Q: How much unused PTO can I carry over?

A: Up to 5 days (40 hours), generally to be used by March 31 of the following year, subject to law.

Q: What are the standard office days?

A: Tuesday and Thursday, with at least 2 onsite days each week for eligible hybrid employees.

Q: When does medical coverage start?

A: Generally the first day of the month after 30 days of employment, subject to plan terms.

Q: How much is the 401(k) employer match?

A: 100% of employee contributions on the first 4% of eligible compensation, subject to plan terms.

Q: What is the professional development allowance?

A: Up to $1,200 per calendar year for eligible full-time employees after 90 days of service.

Q: How quickly should I report a stolen laptop?

A: Immediately and no later than 24 hours after discovering the loss, to security@northstar.example.

Q: How long do I have to submit travel expenses?

A: Within 30 calendar days of the expense date.

Q: When are paydays?

A: The 15th and final calendar day of each month, or the preceding business day when applicable.

Q: Who do I contact about a payroll error?

A: payroll@northstar.example, ideally within five business days after discovering the error.

15. Retrieval test cases and document limitations

Suggested grounded query: "What is the PTO carryover limit and when does it expire?" Expected answer: 5 days (40 hours), generally used by March 31 of the next year (Section 2).

Suggested cross-section query: "I lost my laptop while traveling. Who should I contact and when?" Expected answer: contact security@northstar.example immediately and within 24 hours (Sections 8 and 13).

Suggested multi-hop query: "Can a new employee use the learning budget in month one?" Expected answer: No; eligibility begins after 90 days of service, for full-time employees (Section 10).

Suggested negative query: "What is the company's tuition reimbursement for a master's degree?" Expected answer: The handbook does not specify a separate tuition reimbursement program. Do not invent one.

Source priority: In a real implementation, the controlling plan documents and applicable laws supersede this sample handbook. This document has no amendments or addenda. Answer only using statements in the retrieved content and state when information is not provided.

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